

Towards a Viable Technique for Educating Student Choreographers: A case of The Crab and Active Playhouse

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Abstract

Dance pedagogy in Nigerian higher institutions and informal training spaces faces the recurring challenge of accommodating diverse categories of learners: trained dancers, enthusiastic amateurs, and reluctant participants. Conventional master-apprentice methods, while historically effective, can be inadequate in such mixed contexts where choreographers must guide large groups of students in productions serving both academic and artistic goals. This study proposes the teach-the-trainers technique as a viable and experiential method for educating student choreographers. Drawing on David Kolb's Experiential Learning Theory, it analyzes two productions: Motherland and Bolobolo staged at The Crab (University of Port Harcourt) and Active Playhouse, respectively. By situating the approach within broader debates in Nigerian and global dance pedagogy, the paper demonstrates how this technique fosters collaboration, ownership, and skill transfer. The study concludes that the teach-the-trainers model offers a flexible, sustainable alternative for dance education, while also acknowledging its limitations and proposing directions for future research.

Keywords: Dance pedagogy, Teach-the-trainers, Experiential learning, Nigerian theatre, Choreography

Introduction

Dance, as an embodied aesthetic practice, functions simultaneously as ritual, entertainment, therapy, and political expression (Fowler, 1977; Warburton, 2019). Its teaching, however, poses distinct challenges, especially in Nigerian higher education where student performers often represent diverse categories: trained dancers with formal technique, enthusiastic amateurs with informal backgrounds, and reluctant participants compelled by course requirements (Mainwaring & Krasnow, 2010).

Traditional Nigerian dance pedagogy has long relied on the master-apprentice system, in which knowledge is transmitted through demonstration, repetition, correction, and communal participation (Bakare, 2004; Hobi, 2014). While this method fosters discipline and cultural continuity, it can be rigid and hierarchical, offering limited adaptability to heterogeneous student groups (Sööt & Viskus, 2014). In contemporary contexts particularly within universities and commercial theatre companies this rigidity often leads to disengagement, uneven learning outcomes, and difficulties in sustaining large ensemble performances (Clark, 2007).

Globally, shifts in dance education emphasize learner-centered, experiential, and collaborative approaches. Kolb's (1984) Experiential Learning Theory, for instance, reframes learning as a cyclical process of experience, reflection, conceptualization, and experimentation, which has been applied effectively in creative disciplines (Healey & Jenkins, 2000). Contemporary pedagogy thus highlights flexibility, inclusivity, and reflective practice, aligning with broader movements in higher education that advocate for participatory and transformative learning (Oreck, 2007).

Within this global shift, Nigerian dance education faces the urgent task of innovating models that blend indigenous apprenticeship traditions with modern educational theories. The teach-the-trainers technique where the choreographer trains selected student leaders who, in turn, guide their peers emerges as one such hybrid model. It resonates with African communal learning practices while operationalizing Kolb's experiential cycle.

Methodology

This study adopts a practice-led case study design, focusing on two productions staged in 2022: *Motherland* at The Crab (University of Port Harcourt) and *Bolobolo* at Active Playhouse, Port Harcourt. It is a descriptive study that engages training process of the student dancers in both formal and informal educational contexts.

Through the commercial production of “*Bolobolo*” and “*Motherland*” as performed at The Crab and Active playhouse respectively in 2022, the student dancers were taken through a similar process of dance education

which the teach-the-trainers technique due to the peculiarity of the students in the formal and informal educational contexts. The dancers were subjected to some rigorous training. They were split into sects to ensure an intensive training.

The dance pedagogy involved a systemic process which was a step-by-step method where the dancers get to understand the dances through a mirroring process as they watched the masters. The teaching process required that the dancers were split into sects and sub-sects where some student dancers were appointed among the group, trained with the intention that when they are well taught, they may teach their colleagues. With this approach, the dance pedagogy in both contexts not only become easy but also proved to be an effective method of teaching dance in educational setting using a one-on-one concentrated method.

Participants

Motherland involved undergraduate theatre students, most of whom were non-dance majors but required to participate in a practical performance.

Bolobolo featured semi-professional and novice performers in a commercial theatre company.

Tools and Data Collection

Direct observation of rehearsals.

Documentation of choreographic processes through notes, rehearsal records, and video.

Informal participant feedback about learning experiences.

Rationale

The productions were selected because they represent contrasting contexts formal (university) and informal (commercial theatre) allowing for a comparative exploration of the teach-the-trainers technique.

Towards a Theoretical Framework

David Kolb's Experiential Learning theory (1984) is targeted at replacing traditional methods of learning with new but practical methods. The theory identifies the traditional mode of learning where students just sit and listen in class as obsolete and inefficient while focusing on the need for practical sessions to enhance the educational method and amplify learning. Since learning stems

beyond the perimeters of a school classroom, learning is “the major process of human adaptation” (Kolb, 1984, p. 32). That is, learning in itself is not limited to the four walls of a classroom but the process of acquiring knowledge not necessarily in the school alone. According to Healey and Jenkins(2000), 'experiential learning theory' necessitates experiential activities and practicals such as fieldwork and laboratory sessions. They state thus:

What is important is to systematically take the learner around each stage of the cycle, ensuring that effective links are made between each stage... the core of Kolb's four stage model is a simple description of the learning cycle which shows how experience is translated through reflection into concepts, which in turn are used as guides for active experimentation and the choice of new experiences. Kolb refers to these four stages as: *concrete experience* (CE), *reflective observation* (RO), *abstract conceptualization* (AC) and *active experimentation* (AE). (Kolb, 1984, p.3).

The foregoing emphasizes the need for a departure from traditional ways of learning to more practical ways, that is, moving from the 'abstract-concrete' dimension (AC-CE) and an 'active-reflective' (AE-RO) dimension. In the same vein, Kolb elucidates thus:

Experiential learning theory offers a fundamentally different view of the learning process from that of the behavioural theories of learning based on an empirical epistemology or the more implicit theories of learning that underlie traditional educational methods, methods that for the most part are based on a rational idealist epistemology...This perspective on learning is called “experiential” for two reasons. The first is to tie it clearly to its intellectual origins in the work of Dewey, Lewin, and Piaget. The second reason is to emphasize the central role that experience plays in the learning procesKolb ,1984, p 20).

Kolb's experiential learning theory faults rigidity in education and in the process of learning. In his opinion, learning is multi-dimensional and it will be highly beneficial to accommodate various forms of learning. Thus, experiential learning is particular about a change in learning process and recommends a flexible modification of teaching and learning methods for the benefit of students by proving sustainability of practicals in teaching. As such, “teachers

deciding to develop courses explicitly using experiential methods, including the learning cycle, need to be reassured that this does not mean rejecting what they usually do, or adopting wholesale the theory and its associated practical applications. The approach can readily be developed from what we already do" (Healey & Jenkins, 2000, p. 8). Hence, this study identifies the experiential learning theory as a suitable bedrock for the formulation of the teach-the-trainers technique, an experiential method of enhancing dance pedagogy for dance students in both formal and informal educational settings via a flexible approach to dance education by introducing the dance students to the master-apprentice method where dance is learnt by experience.

Dance: A General Overview

Dance is a universal language expressed through the human body, embodying rhythm, space, and emotion. Across cultures, it fulfills multiple roles: ritual, entertainment, therapy, identity formation, and political expression (Fowler, 1977; Risner, 2000). In Africa, dance is inseparable from daily life, serving as a medium through which communities negotiate spirituality, history, and social cohesion (Bakare, 2004; Hobi, 2014).

Nigerian scholars and choreographers emphasize this integrative nature of dance. Bakare (2004) stresses that choreography in Nigeria is not only an artistic arrangement of movements but also a vehicle for cultural transmission and moral instruction. Similarly, Iyorwuese (2010) observes that Nigerian choreographers often navigate between indigenous aesthetics and Western theatrical conventions, producing hybrid vocabularies that speak to both local identity and global modernity. Ekwueme (2009) further argues that Nigerian dance performance often carries a didactic function, encoding social commentary within its symbolic gestures and movement patterns.

Empirical studies from African contexts highlight how choreographers conceptualize dance pedagogy. For instance, Odunze and Asigbo (2022) report that Nigerian university choreographers regard dance as "embodied history," where teaching must move beyond replication of steps to include storytelling and cultural interpretation. Similarly, Ojuade (2003) documents Yoruba festival dances as pedagogical spaces where younger participants acquire cultural knowledge through

imitation, correction, and improvisation. These perspectives align with Warburton's (2019) assertion that dance pedagogy globally is shifting toward experiential and meaning-centered practices.

In contemporary Nigeria, the challenge lies in balancing indigenous dance vocabularies with the demands of academic curricula and modern theatre industries. Professional choreographers often face pressure to meet both artistic expectations and educational outcomes, particularly when working with students of mixed ability (Clark, 2007; Mainwaring & Krasnow, 2010). African scholars suggest that sustainable models must draw from communal traditions of learning while adapting to institutional contexts. This makes the exploration of peer-led strategies, such as the teach-the-trainers technique, both timely and relevant.

Dance Pedagogy in Perspective

Though dance is an innate ability (Hobi, 2014, p.4) yet, it is expedient that this ability be nurtured and the process of doing this could be very “challenging” (Clark, 2007, p. 19). Warburton recognizes pedagogy as “a discipline that concerns the study of how *best* to teach. Pedagogical practice may be shaped by administrative policy, assessment practice classroom management strategies curricular specialists and the like, but it focuses first and foremost on the art and science of instruction” (Warburton, 2019, p.80). The core of pedagogy is to impart knowledge through series of teachings in the case where there is an instructor and a student. Hence, the agenda is to provoke knowledge and intellect through a defined learning process.

Dance pedagogy began prehistorically with man at the discovery of his ability to move his body rhythmically (dance) to music or sound while inspiring others to simulate what he does. According to Roche and Huddy (2015, p. 150) the art of dance pedagogy (teaching) can be traced back to the “oral tradition where knowledge has been imparted from master teacher to apprentice. The earliest form of dance pedagogy is the 'master teacher to apprentice' approach, where a lead dancer teaches others, who are interested in his art. Sööt and Viskus (2014, p.1193) confirm this as a preexisting teaching method when they corroborate that “dance pedagogy has traditionally followed a transmission model of teaching, where the students learn by imitating specific movement vocabularies modelled by an expert teacher”. Carter (1984, pp. 1-2) attempts an historical overview of dance education when he captures thus:

Dance has occupied a central place in educational theory since the times of the ancient philosophers Plato and Aristotle, who believed that dance contributes to aesthetic, moral, and intellectual values as well as enhancing physical adeptness and overall wellbeing... In America, dance has been a part of education since Colonial times when dance masters provided the more prosperous families with training in graceful bodily movement and social skills. The immediate precursors of our modern approaches to educational dance were those educators who incorporated German theories of gymnastic dancing into programs for physical education.

Similarly, Hobi (2014, p. 8) chronicles that dance pedagogy during the Renaissance and Baroque eras also retained the idea of learning from a 'dance master' before court dance migrated from the ballroom to the stage and dance instruction (learning) developed as a convention. Hence, dance pedagogy is an ancient practice that has followed the 'master teacher to apprentice' method from pre-historical to modern epochs, although with modifications from scholars and dance teachers in different eras.

Technique Development in Dance Education (Pedagogy)

Dance cannot be learnt in isolation from a teacher and conversely, teaching dance is a herculean task (Clark, 2007, p. 19). In relation to the predominant dance teaching style which is the master teacher to apprentice style, it is an unobstructed verity that the art of dance education has always been tied to the availability of a dance teacher. (Hobi 2014, p. 4) capture affirms that "dance cannot be taught by itself without the teacher. It cannot be learned on a computer, or read from a book. The medium of the art of dance is the dancer's body, and dance pedagogy involves close observation and analysis as well as deconstructing and reassembling parts into a whole. The dance instructor must be present and fully engaged". This reveals the sacrosanctity of the dance instructor in the education process, which features a series of practical learning activities. Risner (2000 p. 163) poses a question of whether or not this process of learning can be achieved without necessarily engaging in the activity. He clarifies this clause when state thus:

Nearly half of the ten dancers speak of the length regarding the significance of physically doing the dance as a way of knowing or in epistemological terms, *knowing how*... Is it possible to know the

dance without doing it? Must a dancer do the dance to know it? Or does doing the dance justify the knowledge claim, rather than constitute it? The following accounts would suggest the actual doing of the dance is primary to the construction of knowing and subsequently challenge the focus of epistemology on propositional over practical forms of knowing.

Thus, effective dance education places a necessity on the dance student to learn from a dance master and physically practice the dance movements as this is basic to his/her learning process. Although, there have been attempts to decry the sacrosanctity of the dance teacher by offering an artificial replacement of video technology. The departure is based on the fact that video and computer technology can be engaged as a learning and evaluation platform to displace the physical presence of a dance teacher (master). Parish cited in Oreck (2007, p . 345) posits that “using videotape, students can collect and analyze movement, add personal commentary, and examine and reflect on stage in the dance making process” . Beyond doubts, the idea of engaging video technology with an extension to social media tutorial videos on YouTube has proved possible due to the current demands of technology which requires a flexibility in approach and curriculum (Carter, 1984, p 8), however, the essentiality of physical dance tutors and masters over the intangible 2-Dimensional dance tutors cannot be overruled.

In the education process, the physical dance teacher creates an interpersonal relationship with the dance students and prepares them for an exceptional dance experience. Hobi (2014, p. 76) agrees that the teacher creates a sense of the class, by establishing the 'grace' necessary for the great experience which can be palpable to the students via the teacher's passion and deference which is tangibly experience by the students. The pitfalls of video technology in dance education is the absence of grace, tangibility, passion and experience among other irreplaceable factors as physical dance learning provides a personalized and intensive training opportunity. In this vein, Fowler(1977,p .34) paints the dance teacher as principality vested with knowledge of the principles and methods of dance and is also capable of studying the structure and function of their bodies as well as the psychology of the students. Hobi(2014, p. 40) refers to this as a conventional approach which necessitates a “partnership” between the teacher and the students .

Due to the primary difference factor in skill and training, dance teachers are expected to display variegated teaching techniques. Their variation in strength, abilities, values, personalities, and constraints has a way of shaping and influencing how they teach. Mainwaring and Krasnow(2010, p. 15) developed a workable technique for effective dance education which captures three aspects which cuts across process and goals; influences affecting the dancer and structure and content of the class. In detail, the technique include (a) Process and goals –Smart learning, decision-making by objective, optimizing the self within community, ritualizing respect; (b) Influences affecting the dancer –mentoring, nurturing the learner, creating fun and challenges for all, empowering the self, focusing on the task, thinking about learning; (c) Structure and content of the class –Building foundations, mixing and matching, developing body awareness, embracing body image, embracing the safe and sound, creating enlightened practices .

Hence, in this context, formulating technique in dance education is premised upon the subjective opinion of the dance teacher, who has the business of determining “detail and sequence” as it applies (Fowler , 1978, p. 25). Although in the midst of these differences, the dancer is required to cultivate a learning posture to complete the learning curve. Mainwaring and Krasnow(2010, p. 15) highlights thus:

The ability of a dancer to master a particular skill or technique depends on many factors: physical ability, motor and kinesthetic feedback and learning processes, physical practice, mental practice for skill enhancement, sufficient physiologic rest, motor memory consolidation, appropriate breakdown and acquisition of complex skills, growth and development, knowledge of results through appropriate external feedback transmission mechanisms, and an environment that facilitates learning and a sense of joy and purpose.

Therefore, the idea of technique formulation in dance pedagogy follows a subjective method and this requires the dancer to also conform to the style of the dance teacher to have a productive learning experience.

Synopsis of “Motherland” (2022)

Bakare Ojo Rasaki's “Motherland” is a topical play that highlights corruption in Nigeria. The play mirrors the Nigeria we find ourselves in today.

The story begins with the white woman condemning the children of Aleare. Then she shows them what they did. The scenes begins with celebration of Aleare (Mother Earth), her children gather to celebrate her 62nd birthday, with dances showcasing the difference cultures. However, Okonkwo has another belief which he shares with Basira, Akpevwhehoghene and Yakubu, This belief poisons their minds and they decide to take from their Mother leaving her almost lifeless to the point, she prefers to die than to live. Finally the children resolve to apologize and return all they have taken from their mother.

In pedagogical terms, this production provided fertile ground for testing the teach-the-trainers model because many performers were non-dance majors. The need to balance narrative clarity, technical skill, and group cohesion demanded a peer-led structure.

Kolb's Experiential Learning Cycle in Motherland

Concrete Experience (CE): Students engaged in embodying corruption-themed movement motifs through imitation of the choreographer's demonstrations.

Reflective Observation (RO): Lead dancers, after rehearsals, reflected on how movements such as heavy stomps or bent postures represented oppression.

Abstract Conceptualization (AC): Leaders developed simplified ways to teach peers by connecting dance steps to moral metaphors in the script.

Active Experimentation (AE): Leaders trained their sects, adapting sequences based on peers' feedback and rehearsing until the group achieved cohesion.

Synopsis of "Bolobolo" (2022)

'Bolobolo' revolves around three brothers (triplets). Their names are Amazige, Asamaowe and Indiamawe, their Parents, Kurozukpo and Prekake celebrate their birth and Kurozukpo gives them three gifts. Amazige is given his ancestral Spear, which her used to defend the people and expects he will use it to defend his brothers. Asamaowe is given an amulet to protect them from evil spirits, while Indiamawe is given Kurozukpo's dauntless and untiring spirit meaning he will never run away from battle. Kurozukpo blesses his children and prays they live together in peace and harmony. Amazige marries Fe'ere and she conceives twice, bearing Ekpotwatin and another baby. When their Parents die they grew apart by the day, Indiamawe used the spear to attack a wild beast which ran away with the spear attached to its body. He is forced by his brother Amazige to retrieve the spear and when he does so, on returning home another calamity happens in the house, but one singular act

breaks the camel's back, the slitting open of Amazige's baby to bring out Indiamawe's bead. The gruesome act is as a result of the seed of hatred sown in the heart of Indiamawe by his blood brother Amazige who demanded that he return his spear. Which leads to the death of Amazige's baby and the final splitting of the family.

This production was particularly demanding, requiring performers with mixed backgrounds—some trained, others novices—to master warrior-like movements and ritual gestures. The teach-the-trainers model was critical in making such complexity manageable.

Kolb's Experiential Learning Cycle in Bolobolo

Concrete Experience (CE): Leaders and peers experienced movements collectively, embodying warrior postures and combat motifs.

Reflective Observation (RO): Using video playback, leaders and the choreographer analyzed the precision of symbolic gestures, such as spear thrusts.

Abstract Conceptualization (AC): Leaders translated difficult steps into metaphors—e.g., calling synchronized stomps the “heartbeat of the clan.”

Active Experimentation (AE): Leaders taught their sects, adjusting jumps or battle gestures for novice dancers. Corrections and misalignments fed back into reflection and refinement.

Teach-the-trainers Technique: A Methodology for Dance Pedagogy

The two productions under study are plays performed by the researcher in the year 2022 in Port Harcourt. Using total theatre, music, dance and drama with emphasis on dance, these productions are successful experiments targeted at establishing a viable technique for educating student choreographers via the teach-the-trainers technique. The context for this experiment were the student dancers and choreographers of the Department of Theatre and Film Studies, University of Port Harcourt popularly called “The Crab” and Active Playhouse, a commercial theatre company in the heart of Port Harcourt. These case studies form the formal and informal educational settings engaged during the course of this experiment.

A lot of students have developed a phobia for dancing and at the attempt to dance. Therefore, the idea behind this technique is to enhance the process of

dance pedagogy in both formal and informal educational settings, and assist students to appreciate the art and process of dance creation. Primarily, the students of *The Crab*, especially those who are not dance majors but find themselves in a practical dance production as a prerequisite for a particular semester, course or what have you find it to be quite challenging to relate with other colleagues and perform well as required. On a secondary level, the technique is targeted at finding a solution to the drudgery associated with teaching dance to crowd of non-committed student dancers.

Therefore, as highlighted at the opening of this paper, the teach-the-trainers technique is a deliberate attempt aimed at correcting and redefining the approach to dance pedagogy using a step-by-step method where the dancers are being taught by the master teachers like apprentices in order to teach others. At the beginning of rehearsal, the dancers are grouped into different sects for the benefit of concentration and personal development. Due to the need for versatility in performance, these students, who are basically actors are trained to be singers and professional dancers to fit into the demand of the performances. Hence, they have fresh encounter with dance aside their acting experience, rediscover new talents and get the boldness to choreograph others. Through this step-by-step method, the student dancers get to understand the dances easily as they watched the masters (teacher) take them through an experiential knowledge of the dances. Learning the dances experientially creates a system of togetherness, collaboration and freedom, as the students get attached to the performance via a sense of belonging and ownership provided.

In the cases of “Motherland” and “Bolobolo”, rehearsal starts in sects. That is, the student dancers are split into smaller groups. These groups are led by a selected few student dancers, who have been taught to train others in sub-categories. During the period of rehearsal in both productions, rehearsal kicks off with general exercise which was usually followed by a flexibility exercise referred to as “dancercise” to put the dancers to shape and prepare their bodies for the physical and rigorous exercises. Afterwards, the steps and movements are developed in the form of a workshop to accommodate the dancers and take them through a personal learning process. These movements are explained to them as the creation continued to ascertain that the dancers, especially the lead dancers, understand the underlying meaning of the dances. Upon completion of the movements, music is then added to the dances for rhythm. Though this

technique achieved its aim yet, it will be important to acknowledge the pitfalls of the technique, of course which can be adjusted in the case of subsequent productions. The budding state of the student dancers require that more time be spent with them to teach them the dances, this strengthens the master-apprentice bonding, and at some point they tend to take the familiarity caused by this bonding for granted and likely joke with the dance sessions. Another important pitfall is the eagerness to showcase their new moves prematurely to other colleagues, especially when the movements are still under construction. The performances understudy as performed by student dancers of the formal and informal educational settings to experiment the possibilities and processes involved in dance pedagogy.

Suffice to say that the dancers were quick to accustom themselves to the modality of rehearsal where a group of selected few were taught by the master teacher for the purpose of training others.



Fig 1.1 The dance teacher (researcher) teaching



Fig 1.2 The lead dancer training other dancers lead dancers



Fig 1.3 The dance teacher (researcher) taking the dancers through.



Fig 1.4 The dance teacher using the teach-the-trainers technique.

Another successful use of the teach-the-trainers technique is to develop dancers beyond their relevance or specific role in performance. Oftentimes, some dancers are identified and personally trained from the early stages of their training in the department or at the playhouse, and they are introduced to take up lead roles in performance depending on their level of development as performers.

Critical Reflections and Limitations

While effective, the teach-the-trainers model presents challenges:

Hierarchy in Peer Teaching: Leaders may exercise uneven authority, potentially reinforcing hierarchies.

Differing Skill Levels: Advanced learners progress quickly, while reluctant participants may still lag.

Time and Resources: Dividing into sects requires extra supervision and rehearsal time.

Discipline: Overfamiliarity between peers can lead to reduced seriousness.

These limitations highlight the need for structured timelines, clear supervision, and careful selection of leaders.

Conclusion and Recommendations

This study demonstrates that the teach-the-trainers technique operationalizes Kolb's experiential cycle, providing a flexible, sustainable model for teaching dance in Nigerian universities and theatre companies. Its originality lies in adapting African apprenticeship traditions to modern educational contexts through experiential learning theory.

Contributions:

Offers a Nigerian perspective to global pedagogy debates.

- Provides evidence that peer-led learning fosters engagement and skill transfer.

Highlights leadership as a key learning outcome for student choreographers.

Recommendations:

Replicate the technique across Nigerian institutions and disciplines like music and drama.

Conduct longitudinal studies to assess long-term learning impacts.

Compare applications across African contexts for broader validation.

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